ESSAY · CRITICAL THINKING & AI · PART III: JUDGMENT

The Weight AI Can't Carry

Why data can inform a decision, but only people can own what happens next

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BY LUBNA ALI KHAN · 10 MIN READ · PART III OF III

Start with Parts I and II

Part I, *Some Questions Need Answers From Within*, makes the case for asking your own questions. Part II, *Thinking Beyond the Prompt*, takes it into daily practice. This piece builds on both.

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Part I argued that some questions need answers from within. Part II looked at what that means in daily practice, from prompting to SEO. This third essay moves somewhere heavier: the moment a decision stops being a draft and becomes real.

A Room Everyone Has Sat In

The reports are finished. The numbers are convincing. Someone has built a slide with a green arrow pointing up and to the right, and for a moment the whole room seems to agree on what happens next.

Then someone asks the only question that ever really matters in a meeting like this.

"If this goes wrong, who's responsible?"

The room gets quieter. Not because nobody knows the answer. Because everybody does, and nobody especially wants to say it out loud.

A spreadsheet cannot stand up and take that on. A forecast cannot sit across from a client and explain what happened. Sooner or later, someone in that room has to say some version of "this was my call," and mean it. That has always been true of decisions, in every industry, long before anyone in that room had a laptop open.

Underneath every plan I have ever helped build, that same quiet question was sitting there the whole time, waiting to be asked. Who is actually responsible for this, once it leaves the room.

It's easy to assume that question only belongs in boardrooms, attached to large numbers and legal consequences. It doesn't. A teacher deciding how to grade a borderline essay is answering it. So is an editor deciding whether a piece of writing is honest enough to publish under someone's name, usually without anyone in the room noticing the question was even being asked.

What Changes and What Doesn't

Every generation gets handed better instruments. A compass made it possible to cross an ocean without guessing. A ledger made it possible to know whether a business was actually making money or only felt like it was. None of these tools ever asked to be trusted blindly. They did their part, and a person still had to decide what to do with what the instrument showed them.

That pattern hasn't changed, even as the instruments have gotten dramatically more capable. What has changed is how easy it has become to forget the second half of it exists at all. A compass never argued with the sailor holding it. A tool that answers instantly and confidently is a different kind of instrument,

because it starts to feel like it is also deciding. It isn't. It was never built to.

This is where artificial intelligence enters the conversation, later than usual, because the point being made here isn't really about AI. It's about something AI happens to make unusually visible: the gap between having information and being accountable for what you do with it. That gap has existed since long before anyone could type a question into a box and receive an answer in seconds. AI hasn't created it. It has simply made it harder to ignore, because the answers now arrive faster than the habit of questioning them has had time to catch up.

Prediction Is Not the Same as Judgment

One of the easiest mistakes to make about AI, especially among people who use it well for everything else, is treating prediction and judgment as though they were the same skill wearing different clothes. They aren't.

Prediction asks what is most likely to happen. Judgment asks what should be done about it. A forecast can tell you there is an eighty percent chance of rain. It cannot tell you whether the wedding should move indoors, because that decision depends on things no forecast has access to: how much the family has already spent, how the bride actually feels about the tent, what matters more this weekend than staying dry.

An AI model can flag a loan application as high risk with impressive accuracy. It cannot tell you whether declining it is fair, because fairness isn't a pattern in historical data. It's a judgment about a person, made by another person, who then has to live with having made it.

A market model can predict, with real precision, how a stock is likely to move over the next quarter. It has no view on whether a retired couple should put their savings into it, because that decision depends on things no model has access to: how they'd feel losing a third of it, what they've already lived through, what they actually need the money for.

Data narrows the range of reasonable decisions. It rarely makes the decision itself, and the moment we start treating a confident output as though it had, something quietly slips out of our hands that we probably meant to keep.

The Room Behind the Recommendation

Picture a hiring manager working through a stack of applications with help from a tool that scores resumes, flags strong candidates, and summarises interview transcripts overnight. All of that is genuinely useful. None of it changes what happens at the end of the process, when one name has to be chosen and a person has to be comfortable defending that choice months later if things don't work out.

Or a physician looking at a scan alongside a tool that has flagged a pattern worth investigating. The tool did something valuable, something that might have taken a human eye far longer to notice on its own. But somewhere down the hall, a physician still has to sit across from a patient and say, in their own voice, "here is what I think we should do," and be the one who answers for it if the recommendation turns out to be wrong.

Or a bank's fraud system, quietly comparing a transaction against millions of others and flagging it as suspicious within milliseconds. Genuinely impressive work, the kind no human team could match at that speed. But someone still has to decide whether to actually freeze the account, knowing that if they're wrong, a family loses access to their own money in the middle of an ordinary Tuesday, and someone has to answer for that too.

> *The tool informs. The person still has to decide, and then live inside the consequences of having decided.*

Confidence Is Not Wisdom

There is something worth sitting with here, and it isn't really about machines at all. It's about how persuasive confidence is, regardless of where it comes from.

Wise people have been remarkably comfortable saying "I don't know" when they meant it. A tool built to produce an answer will produce one, because producing an answer is what it exists to do, and it will do so in a tone that sounds exactly as sure of a hard question as an easy one. That evenness of tone is not the same thing as being right, though it is very easy to mistake for it when you're tired, behind schedule, and looking for permission to stop deliberating.

The most dangerous decisions rarely announce themselves as uncertain. They arrive dressed as confidence, borrowed from a source that had no way of knowing whether it had actually earned that confidence in the first place. Nobody questions it, because questioning something that sounds that sure of itself takes a kind of stubbornness most people don't have energy for at four in the afternoon.

That stubbornness matters more now than it used to, not less. The easier it becomes to get a confident-sounding answer, the more valuable it becomes to be the person willing to ask, gently, whether the confidence is actually earned.

Nobody Says "The Tool Told Me To"

Every meaningful decision leaves a mark somewhere. Some of those marks are financial. Some are legal. Some show up much later, in a conversation nobody wanted to have.

Try explaining to a customer why their application was declined, or to an employee why their role was cut, using only "the system recommended it" as your reason. It doesn't hold. It was never going to hold, in any era, because responsibility has never actually lived in the tool. It lives in whoever chose to act on what the tool said, which is exactly why leadership has never really been about making flawless decisions. It has always been about being willing to own the ones that turn out to be wrong.

This is, I think, the part that gets lost most easily in conversations about AI and work. People worry, reasonably, about whether a tool will replace their job. Fewer people ask the harder question underneath it: even if the tool does most of the thinking, who is still willing to stand behind what it produced. That second question has nothing to do with how capable the tool is. It has everything to do with whether a person is still willing to sign their name to the outcome.

What AI Carries, and What It Can't

AI can process a staggering amount of information. It can notice patterns a person would take years to spot, if they ever spotted them at all. It can hold a thousand possibilities in view at once, without getting tired or defensive about any of them.

All of that deserves genuine respect. None of it amounts to authority.

Authority belongs to whoever is willing to live with what happens after the decision is made. Information can be generated in an instant and handed to anyone who asks. Responsibility can't be handed off quite so easily. One of those things scales. The other one, stubbornly, still requires a person.

This is easy to agree with in principle and easy to forget in practice, especially under deadline. When a tool hands you something polished and mostly right, there's a real pull toward treating "mostly right" as "good enough to sign off on without really checking." That pull isn't a flaw in the tool. It's a very old, very human shortcut, and it existed long before anyone had a model to blame it on. AI just makes the shortcut more tempting, because the output looks so finished that questioning it can feel almost unreasonable.

Closer to Home Than It Looks

None of this stays confined to hospitals and banks. It shows up in far smaller rooms too, including the ones I work in most days.

A brand asks for a piece of thought leadership under its founder's name. A tool can produce something fluent and reasonably accurate in a few seconds. What it cannot do is know whether the founder actually believes the claim being made, or whether it quietly overstates something the company hasn't

earned yet. Publishing that piece is still a decision, made by a person, and if the claim turns out to be wrong or misleading, nobody credible is going to accept "the draft came out that way" as an explanation.

I've sat with early drafts that read beautifully and said almost nothing true about the client sitting across from me. The sentences were fine. The judgment about whether they belonged in the world was missing, and that judgment was mine to supply, not the tool's. That's a small example next to a hospital or a bank, but it follows the same shape. Fluency isn't the same as accountability. Somebody still has to decide whether a piece of writing deserves to exist under a real name.

Bringing It Together

Part I argued that some questions only get answered by asking them yourself. Part II argued that good work, prompts included, starts with a decision someone actually made rather than one that was skipped. This piece adds one more link to that chain. Clear thinking becomes judgment. Judgment becomes action. Action becomes something a person has to answer for, whether it goes well or badly.

AI hasn't broken that chain. It has simply sped up every step of it, which means the moment where a human being has to step in and own the outcome now arrives faster than it used to, with less time to notice it's arrived at all. That speed is not a small thing. It means the habit of pausing before signing off on something, always useful, is now more useful than it has ever been, precisely because the pause has to be chosen rather than imposed by how long the work used to take.

A Closing Reflection

Future readers will probably remember this era for the tools it built. I'd like to think they also remember the people who understood exactly where those tools stopped and where a person had to begin.

That place isn't found by rejecting the tools, and it isn't found by handing them more trust than they've earned either. It's found somewhere in between, in the willingness to use everything available and still say, at the end, this decision is mine.

I don't think that willingness is rare because people lack the judgment for it. I think it's rare because it's uncomfortable, and comfort is easy to mistake for wisdom when a fast, fluent answer is sitting right there, asking for almost nothing in return except your trust.

Someone still signs the agreement.

Someone still answers for what happens next, especially when it doesn't go the way the forecast said it would.

That is the weight AI can't carry.

The Weight AI Can't Carry by Lubna Ali Khan. Part III of the Critical Thinking & AI series.
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